CHAPTER 27

MONTY AND ME

12 July 2009

ENGLAND vs AUSTRALIA, 1st Test, *Sophia Gardens*, *Cardiff*

England 435 and 252/9; Australia 674/6 dec.

Match Drawn

2nd innings: **J Anderson 21 not out**

There is the silence of 16,000 people. And to add to the funereal backdrop, appearing out of the pavilion, separating from the collection and blur of bodies and eventually coming into focus – his figure so distinctly and identifiably him – Monty Panesar is walking towards me. Even from this distance, as he walks over the rope and past the Australian fielders, I can see his eyes are extremely wide and wired. He looks like he's been awake for days, as if he may have been in a padded room, single-handedly trying to solve some sort of conspiracy theory. He doesn't seem to really know where he is – a look of genuine, startled fear pressing itself on him. As he approaches, he jogs for a second, his legs tied and slightly buckling over each other like a newborn deer.

We touch gloves. It's the touch of two people pretending. We've seen batters do this, the touch. It's a statement of control. It says 'we've got this' when we really cannot in any stretch of the imagination be sure that we've got this. There are
11.3 overs to survive the first Ashes Test of the summer. It's just me and Monty between the Australians and victory. The very fact Monty is batting below me in the batting order tells a story to everyone, us included, that the likelihood of us surviving is close to nil. Neither of us has history of pulling